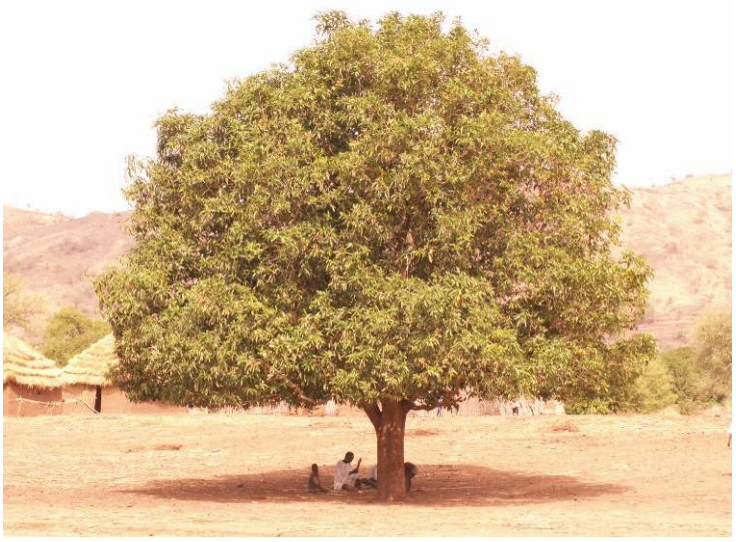
# NUPE DICTIONARY



**[DRAFT -PREPARED FOR COMMENT ONLY]**

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## Nupe phonology

The transcriptions used here are intended to represent Nupe as fully as possible, in terms of both tone and vowel length, and may therefore differ from locally published materials. The vowels, consonants and tones are first described and then the orthography used is indicated below.

### Vowels

Nupe has five vowels;

| | **Front** | **Central** | **Back** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Close** | i | | u |
| **Close-Mid** | e | | o |
| **Open** | | a | |

In Banfield's original orthography he gives two additional symbols, ạ and ọ for vowels, which seem sometimes to conflate nasalisation and a mishearing of vowel quality.

### Long vowels in Nupe?

Smith (1967a) argues that in words such **baagi** the /aa/ is a phonemically distinct long vowel, although it is difficult to find minimal pairs to support this hypothesis. Madugu (in various references) transcribes long vowels, such as **déégi** 'small, few' although he does not comment on this. The relatively few words that appear to have a surface long vowel will be marked.

There are three nasalised vowels;

| | **Front** | **Central** | **Back** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Close** | i | | u |
| **Open** | | a | |

Nupe can close a syllable with a nasal and can occasionally contrast CVN and CṼN. For example;

The representation of nasalisation is one of the most problematic aspects of the orthography. It is always represented by a following –n and this can lead to confusion with a syllabic /n/. In this document nasalisation follows an IPA-like system. However, this is often counterintuitive to speakers.

Representation of these three vowels was not entirely consistent in Banfield, since the close vowels were represented as V + n and the central vowel as ạ[1]. Nupe pronunciation of the nasalised central vowel is definitely not entirely consistent. The word /**sarayi**/ 'beautiful' seems to be realised as;

/sãrãyi/
/sarãyi/
/sarayi/

probably suggesting that over time the nasalisation may simply be lost.

[1] Although Banfield (1914:xx) describes this sound as '

**Consonants**

Nupe consonants are as follows;

| | Bilabial | Labio-dental | Alveolar | Alveopalatal | Palatal | Velar |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Plosive | p b | | t d | tʃ dʒ | kp gb | k g |
| Fricative | | f v | s z | | | h |
| Affricates | | | ts dz | | | |
| Nasal | m | | n | | | |
| Lateral | | | l | | | |
| Tap/trill | | | | r | | |
| Approximant | w | | | | y | |

Syllable-final nasals are homorganic with the following consonant. Nupe has extensive labialisation and palatalisation and combinations of both prosodies.

**Tones**

Nupe has three level tones and falling and rising tones, marked as follows;

| | |
|---|---|
| High | ˊ |
| Mid | Unmarked |
| Low | ˋ |
| Rising | ˇ |
| Falling | ˆ |

All tones are marked, where possible, but in the present version where botanists' transcriptions have not been rechecked in the field, some words are not tone-marked.

**Nupe orthography**

**Orthography of conventions**

tʃ = c

dʒ = j

The order of letters is; a, b, c, d, e, f, g, h, i, j, k, l, m, n, o, p, r, s, t, u, v, w, y, z.

There are also the digraphs; ts, dz, gb, kp which are written with two or more letters in English but are in fact only one sound. Technically speaking, affricates such as 'ts' etc. are distinct sounds. However, for those familiar with the principles of English alphabetisation, it is probably safer to treat them as composed of two separate letters. So 'gb' will be found as part of the letter 'g' rather than as a separate heading.

Missing words: winnowing tray, guest

## Nupe-English

Key to codes used in column 3.

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| a | architecture | | | mt | mat |
| ad | animal disease | e | emotions | p | person |
| | | et | ethnonym | | |
| ai | agricultural implement | f | fish | pd | personal decoration |
| am | amphibian | | | | |
| an | ant | fa | farming | | |
| ap | animal part | fo | food | pl | plant |
| | | fr | fruit | po | pot |
| b | bird | g | grass | r | reptile, amphibian |
| bd | bead | ga | game | s | snake |
| bf | bodily fluid | go | gourd | sa | salutation |
| bm | body mark, sore etc. | gr | grasshopper | sh | shrub |
| bp | body part | h | herb | so | song |
| | | hb | horse breed | | |
| bs | basket | hc | horse colour | t | tree |
| c | crop | hg | horse gear | | |
| ca | canoe terms | hu | hunting equipment | ti | title |
| cc | chicken colour | i | insect | tm | temporal (adverbs) |
| ch | charm, amulet | is | Islam | to | tool |
| co | colour | k | kinship | tp | tree part |
| cr | crustacean | la | landscape | tr | traditional religion |
| d | disease, sickness | ma | mammal | tx | textile |
| da | domestic animal | me | medicine | v | vine |
| dc | dance | mi | musical instrument | vc | vendors' call |
| | | | | w | water (river etc.) |
| | | | | wf | warfare |
| | | mn | mineral | wp | weapon |
| dk | drink | mo | money | wv | weaving |
| dr | item of dress | | | wt | weather |
| | | | | z | zoological term |

| Nupe | PoS | C | English | Additional information |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **A.** | | | | |
| **a** | pron. | | They; them; | Following combinations are made which express the emphatic:- **atsó, a bè 'tí a nyi, a bè 'ti tacì̀ a nyi, atsó bè egwa a nyi**. |
| **a ǎà** | adv. | | No; | the reduplicated form is frequently used, especially in expressing disapproval; |
| **á** | aux. | | Present Perfect Tense marker | |
| **à** | adv. | | Negative marker | always placed at the end of a sentence |
| **'à** | aux. | | Shall; will; should; would; | a contraction of **gà**. |
| **á** | excl. | | Exclamation of surprise. | |
| **à** | excl. | | Exclamation expressing the opposite of surprise. | |
| **ǎ** | excl. | | Exclamation expressing doubt. | |
| **ába** | excl. | | Of course; just so; | cf. **áka**. |
| **àbàdâ** | n.<br>adv. | | Eternal; everlasting;.<br>forever | |
| **a bè 'tí a nyi** | pron. phr. | | They themselves; | cf. **a**. |
| **ábèke... n** | conj. | | If; suppose, or supposing that; | Following combinations are also used:- **kábèke...nã, wũ áyìke...nã, wũ ábèke...nã**. |
| **abîgì** | excl. | | Salutation given to a twin; | cf. **èbà**. |
| **a bo'za** | ? | | it is the fault of | |
| **acigìrǐ** | n. | wp | Iron-shafted flat-bladed spear used by the Hausa | |
| **ácì̀** | conj. | | Thus; so; a word of assent; | Also used in the following combinations:- **ácì̀gă, ácĩgă, mã, ácì̀gă tsá, ácì̀gă tsá mã, ácì̀ tsá, ácì̀ tsá mã**. |
| **àdà̀mà̀gi** | n. | | Trade flint-lock gun; | cf. **àtấkòʃi, bindìga**. |
| **adà̀n bírìgi** | n. | | Nickname for a **kấnã** monkey | also **ndă 'dà̀ bírìgì**, or **ndă adà̀n bírìgì**. **Bírì** is the Hausa for monkey. |
| **Adidya** | n. | | Salutation for the rank **Garà**. | |
| **àdǐko** | n. | dr | Handkerchief tied at each corner and hung on the shoulder. | |
| **àdímù** | a. | | Compulsory; | |
| **adìnkoro** | n. | g | Swamp grass, | used for horse feed. |
| **àdǐni** | n.<br>a. | is | Religion<br>religious | |
| **àdǔwa** | n.<br>a.<br>v. | | Prayer.<br>prayerful<br>to pray | |
| **ádúwaci** | n. | t | Desert date | The fruit is edible and gum is obtained from it. *Balanites aegyptiaca*. < Hausa |

| Nupe | PoS | C | English | Additional information |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **ádwáni** | num. | | Seventy | |
| **ádzùn** | n. | | Coming out | |
| **ádzùn nyika** | n. | | Protruding teeth | |
| **àfâ** | p.n. | ti | Islamic teacher, | saluted as **ʃùgàba**. |
| **àfàce** | conj.<br>prep. | | Except<br>unless | |
| **àfàtà** | n. | fr | Cola nut type with many segments. | |
| **àfè** | conj. | | Except; unless; | cf. **àfàce**. |
| **agábá** | n. | | Salutation for certain village chiefs; | signifies 'lion'. See **zákì**. |
| **ágábà** | n. | | Salutation for the rank **Tswanyɛ̀**. | |
| **agàna** | n. | ad | Horse disease | |
| **agãdãwuci** | n. | dr | European style of trousers | |
| **àgɛ̆rúmã** | | | | See **àngɛ̆rúmã** which is more commonly used. |
| **àgbɛ̆** | n. | wp | field gun or cannon. | |
| **àgbɛ̆tì** | n. | | Salutation for the rank **Légãmã**. | |
| **àgbyàdya** | n. | c | Cucumber, | also **àgbiàja** and **gbiàja**. |
| **àgbyàja** | n. | | See **àgbiàdia**. | |
| **àgbòrɨ̆** | | | See **àngbòrɨ̆**. | |
| **àgyàkà** | n. | m | Large house rat. | See **etsú**. |
| **agí aké áʃɪ̃ʃɪ̃** | n. | b | Bird like a woodthrush, whose chirp is imitated to from its name, which means, "they eat and leave and lay aside." | |
| **agyákʊ̆̀** | n. | sa | Salutation for the rank **Lile**; | = 'they eat and shake themselves' |
| **Àgùdà** | p.n. | | French traders of the early period | |
| **agúmɛ́** | n. | sa | Salutation for the ruler of **Bàsà**. | |
| **ahá àhá** | excl. | | Exclamation of satisfaction. | |
| **ajemí** | a. | | Foreign. | < Hausa |
| **ájɪ̃** | v.a. | | Do | used in interrogative sentences; |
| **áka** | excl. | | Of course; just so; cf. **ába**. | |
| **àkàngu** | n. | cr | Spiny mussel | *Etheria elliptica*. Frequently used to scrape out the inside of pots. |
| **àkíka** | adv. | | Truly; verily; indeed | cf. **gɛ̀ʃɪkiya**. |
| **àkíka** | a. | | true | cf. **gɛ̀ʃɪkiya**. |
| **Àkókó** | p.n. | et | Akoko people in Northern Ondo | |
| **akowoji** | n. | fg | Drift-net operated from a riverside platform | Illustrated in Reed *et al.* (p. 151) |
| **àkpárà** | n. | | European rifle; cartridge; | |
| **a kpe ʃi à** | adv.p. | | There is no telling; no one knows; | lit. no one knows beforehand. |

| Nupe | PoS | C | English | Additional information |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **àkú** | n. | b | African grey parrot | < Hausa? |
| **ákù ánkù** | a. | | Perfectly true; | cf. **ácɛ̀, àkíka, gɛ̃ʃikiya**. |
| **ákù ánkù** | n. | | English checked matting. | |
| **àkùtiàgi** | n. | wp | Small trade flint-lock gun; also pistol or revolver. | |
| **àkwàwŭ** | n. | | Local clerk; | also applied to Africans dressed in European attire. |
| **al-** | aff. | | Arabic article. | Some words follow al- with an epenthetic vowel, a, i, or u, to prevent a sequence of two consonants. Thus **aliherì**; **alhájì** becomes **alahájì**; and *albasa* **àlùbăsa**. |
| **àlăda** | n. | | Custom; observance; manner; form; habit; | cf. **ʒìʒì**. |
| **àladè** | n. | | Sunday. | < Hausa |
| **alágo** | n. | tx | Heavy white Croydon cloth. | |
| **alahájì** | n. | | One who has performed the pilgrimage to Mecca | cf. **àlăʒì**. |
| **àlăjìbi** | a. | | Wonderful; astonishing; marvellous; | cf. **yĕka**. |
| **àlàlî** | n. | tx | Local silk dyed red; | cf. **tsamiã** |
| **àlalì** | a. | | Rightful: lawful; applied to possessions both of customs and property: | |
| **àlămãni** | n. | | Way; trait; characteristic; | |
| **àlàmî** | n. | | Thursday. | < Hausa |
| **àlàmu** | n. | | Idea; suspicion; | |
| **àlăsɛ̃ngi** | n. | g | Swamp grass. | |
| **àlăʒì** | n. | | One who has performed the pilgrimage to Mecca, and on that account dresses in white; | whence applied as an a. white, to white animals; **dòkò àlăʒì**; cf. **alahájì**. |
| **àlbăríka** | n. | | Blessing; | cf. **àlùbăríka**. < Arabic |
| **àlbàrû** *also* **àlùbàrû** | n. | wp | Gunpowder. | |
| **àleki** | n. | | Sin; fault; offence; that which is wrong; | cf. **lefi**. |
| **àlĕwà** | n. | fo | Sweet made from melted sugar | <Arabic via Hausa |
| **ali** | n. | | Habit; character; | cf. **eli**. |
| **àlìfíntì** | n. | tx | English drill cloth. | |
| **álígà** | a. | co | Green. | |
| **àlìgãríwò** | n. | fo | Sweet | Originally made from honey and the fruit of the **gŭgoró** tree, but now usually from packaged sugar. |
| **àlìgĕta** | n. | mi | Shawm used to lead the ensemble of trumpeters which play for the Etsu Nupe. | <Arabic via Hausa |
| **àlìherì àlherì** | n. | | Kindness; goodness; | cf. **cèto**. |
| **àlijĕnã** | n. | is | The Muslim heaven. | <Arabic via Hausa |
| **àlìjènu** | n. | | Spirit or demon; | cf. also under **bàtɛ́**. |

| Nupe | PoS | C | English | Additional information |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **àlìkáfa àlìkáifa** | n. | hg | Stirrup; used idiomatically means prosperity; | |
| **àlìkali** | n. | | Judge; | the salutations for this office are, **Kùlĭyà, Guruzà, Zhiàkǎ̀tàra, Bìlàhakì, Mǎ̀gǎ̀áwólŏ**; cf. **ebógáci**. <Arabic via Hausa |
| **alikaràra** | a. | hc | Dappled grey (horse). | |
| **àlìkáwòli** | n. | | Agreement; promise; contract; covenant; | cf. **lá egǎ̃ ʃíʃì**. |
| **alikawòli** | a. | hc | Jet black (horse); | |
| **àlìkǎ́là̀mi** | n. | | Pen; pencil; quill or reed; anything used for writing. | |
| **àlìkiangi** | n. | g | Field grass, | used for horse feed. |
| **àlìkímba** | n. | dr | Hooded cloak or cape. | |
| **àlìkinla** | n. | tx | Blue and white striped cloth. | |
| **àlìkiyiómã** | a. | is | The Last Day. | |
| **àlìmãn gorozo** | n. | sa | Salutation for the rank **Kpòtũ**. | |
| **àlìmǎ̀saki** | n. | p | Pauper; destitute person; | cf. **ètsa**. |
| **àlìsâ** | n. | wp | Bullet; cartridge; ammunition; shot. | |
| **álísáwòli** | n. | hg | Halter rope. | |
| **álíʃìà** | a. | hc | Cream coloured (horse). | |
| **alìyára** | n. | sa | Salutation for the rank **Sokiára**. | |
| **àlòba** | n. | d | Plague | cf. **pãmvũgi**. |
| **àlùbǎríka** | n. | | Blessings; thanks | cf. **salbǎríkà**. |
| **àlùbǎsa** | n. | c | Onion | <Arabic via Hausa |
| **àlùbŏta** | n. | tx | Trade cloth. | |
| **àlùfâ** | p.n. | ti | Islamic teacher, | See **àfâ**. |
| **alúgbó** | excl. | sa | Salutation for the ranks **Ndǎkótsu** and **Nnǎ̀kótsu**. | Also **arúgbó** |
| **àlùgŭsù** | n. | | Deceit | |
| **àlùgŭsù** | v. | | to deceive. | |
| **àlùhúmã** | n. | | Disciple; follower; | cf. **àlùmǎjǎ̀ri**. |
| **álúkámã** | n. | | Wheat | <Arabic via Hausa |
| **àlùkòranù** | n. | is | The Koran; | cf. **kòranù**. <Arabic via Hausa |
| **àlùkúndì** | n. | | Medicine said to bring riches. | |
| **àlùmǎfiki** | n. | | Hypocrite; | cf. **mǎ̀nǎfiki**. |
| **àlùmǎjǎ̀ri, àlùmǎzǎ̀ri** | n. | | Disciple; devotee; | cf. **àlùhúmã, ezà zŭ̀mǎ̀**. |
| **àlùmǎkǎ̀ʃì** | n. | | Scissors; shears | |
| **àlùmuwòzinǎ̀** | n. | | Salutation for **Làdàn**, the mosque crier. | <Arabic |
| **àlùwaʃi** | n. | | Boasting; bragging; | cf. **fári, bàʒì**. |
| **alúwó alúwó matúwó** | n. | | Salutation for the rank **Ságì**. | |
| **àlùzwălùmi** | n. | | Fraud; v. to defraud; | cf. **àzwălùmi**. |
| **àmâ** | conj. | | But. | <Hausa |
| **ámálì** | n. | sa | Salutation for the ranks **Ńdàejì**, **Tsádúkó**, **Tswánkwá**, **Dòkòdzà**: | |
| **ámálì** | a. | | big, as applied to male | **dòkò ámálì**, a big horse. |

| Nupe | PoS | C | English | Additional information |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | animals | |
| **àmănã** | n. | | Forced levy; an unlawful exaction; | |
| **ámáwòlì** | n. | dr | Veil | part of the turban worn over the mouth and hanging down over the chest. |
| **àmằdìgi** | n. | i | Caterpillar covered with poisonous hairs. | |
| **àmĭ** | excl. | | Amen. | |
| **ámínci** | n. | | Friendship; confidence; | cf. **dá 'yà**. |
| **àmĭla** | n. | wp | Sword belt. | |
| **amùsà** | a. | is | Forbidden; meat not killed in accordance with Moslem law. | |
| **ănã** | a. | | This; | cf. **nãnã**. |
| **ànằbì** | n. | is | Prophet. | |
| **ànằsara** | n. | | Christian | |
| **ànằʃèwa nằʃèwa** | n. | | Play; amusement; sport; v. **jĩ ànằʃèwa**, to play; a. playful; merry; senseless; | cf. **ráhà**. |
| **ànemù** | n. | | Salutation for the office **Nắyémi**. | |
| **ànfàni** | n. | | Profit; advantage; use; benefit; | <Hausa |
| **ángálè** | n. | mi | Drum ensemble originally deriving from Lokoja. | The leader plays a set of four cylindrical **gálè** drums arranged on the ground in a semi-circle. |
| **àngắrúmã** | n. | hb | Breed of very tall horses; war horse. | |
| **àngbòrĭ àngòrĭ** | n. | | Small clasp knife. | |
| **aní** | adv. | | Already; | when used after a verb it forms the perfect tense; |
| **áníngá** | adv. | | Thus; so; | cf. **ácì̃**. |
| **ànini** | n. | | Old coin representing a tenth of a penny. | Disappeared from use in the 1960s but still symbolising a small sum of money. |
| **ànĭyã** | n. | | Intention; desire; mind; purpose; diligence; zeal; | |
| **ànkakà** | n. | bd | Long tubular beads. | |
| **ánkù** | | | See **ákù**. | |
| **àntelè** | n. | tx | Silk or satin cloth. | |
| **ànŭri** | n. | | Vision; insight; enlightenment; | |
| **ányíci** | n. | | Slander; defamation; | cf. **áʃìáda**. |
| **anzãri** | n. | | Keenness; | cf. **yĕwõn**. |
| **áràárà** | n. | da | Large Borno ram. | |
| **aradù** | | | See **rádi, sòkógbà**. | |
| **àrằmù** | n. | | That which is unlawful; that which is unjust; | |
| **áráta** | num. | | Fifty. | |
| **áràʃĩ** | a. | hc | Bay (horse). | |

| Nupe | PoS | C | English | Additional information |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **arèwa** | n. | | North. | |
| **àrìdã** | n. | t | Tree whose fruit is used for medicine. | or **àyìdã** |
| **árìgi** | n. | | Hunger; | a word rarely used; cf. **mãdã**. |
| **aro** | n. | | Loan; used with the verb **jĩ** it signifies to borrow or to lend; | |
| **àròdi** | n. | | Bottled perfume; | cf. **àrùwòdi, tùràre, àtùʃîân**. |
| **àròla** | n. | is | Muslim ceremonial ablutions which precede prayer. | |
| **àrùgbĕ** | n. | dc | Rhythm played on a drum to praise the **enyamaci** magicians. | |
| **àrùkù** | n. | | Medicine generally; | (rare) cf. **cigbè**. |
| **árúkù** | n. | | Hulk; | cf. **eyatí kolú**. |
| **árúkù** | n. | | Sneak. | |
| **àruʃi** | excl. | sa | Salutation to a man undergoing marriage ceremonies | |
| **àrùwòdi** | n. | | Bottled perfume; | cf. **àròdi**. |
| **arwatwà** | a. | | Fat | |
| **àsá** | excl. | | Exclamation of surprise. | |
| **àsábárú** | n. | b | Parrot | < Hausa |
| **ásádĭ̃** | n. | wp | Extra long-barrelled gun; | cf. **bindiga**. |
| **àsàlatù** | n. | is | Repetition of the rosary. | |
| **àsára** | n. | | Loss; misfortune; adversity. | |
| **asãli** | n, | | Origin: beginning; | cf. **mãfari**. |
| **ásắmù** | n. | | Poison administered internally. | |
| **asằngò** | n. | sa | Salutation for the rank **Ságì.** | |
| **àsê** | excl. | | Exclamation of surprise. | See **àsá**. |
| **àsíbì** | n. | | Saturday. | or **àʃíbì** |
| **asike** | n. | | Light; brightness; reflection; v. **jin asike**, shine, glitter; reflect; | cf. **bàyĕtin**. |
| **àsiri àʃiri** | n. | | Secret; adv. secretly; a. secret; | |
| **àsírì** | a. | | Wonderful; astonishing; | cf. **àlăjìbi, yĕka**. |
| **àsùbâ** | n. | | Dawn; | |
| **àʃê** | excl. | | Exclamation of surprise. | See **àsá**. |
| **àʃìá** | excl. | | Exclamation of surprise. | See **àsá**. |
| **áʃìáda** | n. | | Slander; v. **jin áʃìáda**, to slander; | cf. **ányíci**. |
| **áʃìa#mù** | n. | | Powerful solvent which destroys the teeth. | |
| **àtàmâ tàmâ** | n. | | Hope; expectation; v. **jin tàmâ**, to hope; to expect; | cf. **túyé**. |
| **átárà** | n. | | Cola nut type | |
| **àtarùbù** | n. | c | Large chili pepper, less hot than the small type. | < Hausa |
| **àtaura** | n. | | The Mosaic low; ordinance; the Pentateuch. | |
| **atázằri** | n. | p | Very wealthy person; | cf. **ewódeci**. |